IN A DARK ALLEY IN CHANDERI, A YOUNG MAN IS LOST IN A sing-like-nobody's-listening, messed-up rendition of Nigerian singer Rema and Selena Gomez's hit track 'Calm Down'. He is waiting for his friend who seconds earlier has finished humming the lullaby 'Soft Chitti, Warm Chitti' (a nod to 'Soft Kitty' from *The Big Bang Theory*) to his girlfriend. Soon, a gross, ginormous headless monster, called what else but Sarkata, enters a room, hides his decapitated head under the bed and then abducts Chitti. As the audience rides this roller-coaster of laughs and scares, *Stree 2* has casually strode on to become the second highest-grossing Hindi film of all time in India, projected to eclipse the Rs 554 crore *Jawan*. Made on less than half the budget of the Shah Rukh Khan-starring action-heavy spectacle, a riot of a cast, one-liners that keep coming feverishly and a subtle 'smash the patriarchy' messaging have seen the horror comedy mint Rs 530 crore already.

Stree 2 isn't even this year's first horror comedy success. *Munjya*, minus any discernible star and fronted by a VFX-created child monster, led the way in June, surprising all by earning over Rs 100 crore. Come November 1, you will have *Bhool Bhulaiyaa 3*, the third part of one of the first horcoms. Expect it to open big, 2022's *BB2* having collected Rs 180 crore. Safe, then, to say that 2024 is the year of the horror comedy.

Stree 2's success also goes beyond just its lofty figures. For one, it's the rare franchise that's named after a woman, a witch no less, and one that is not riding on the shoulders of a star. The film relies instead on a talented cast—Shraddha Kapoor (unnamed character), Rajkummar Rao (Vicky pronounced Bicky), Abhishek Banerjee (Jana), Aparshakti Khurana (Bittu) and Pankaj Tripathi (Rudra Bhaiyya)—all of whom may not fit the narrow definition of stars but who have become stars in their own right playing the characters for the franchise. Rao is familiar with the chops required to elicit laughs in horror—*Ragini MMS* is a fine example. "I feel there's comedy in tragedy somewhere," he says. "Mr Chaplin's whole career is based on it. What I am doing in *Stree 2* is absolutely tragic—I'm shit scared encountering ghosts and

MONSTER HITS

The horror comedies that have set cash registers ringing



GO GOA GONE (2013) ↑

Budget: ₹19 CR
Box Office Returns: ₹24 CR

In this Raj & DK-directed zombie horror, a rave party in Goa goes hilariously wrong. Kunal Khemu, Vir Das and Anand Tiwari are caught in the chaos with Saif Ali Khan's Russian mobster Boris, a zombie hunter and laugh generator with a fake accent



STREE (2018) ↑

Budget: ₹21 CR
B.O. returns: ₹135 CR

A man-hunting witch named Stree prowls the streets at night in the small town of Chanderi. Hence, the "O Stree Kal Aana" signs outside all the houses. Vicky (Rajkummar Rao) has no idea what he's signed up for as he falls hard for the mysterious belle (Shraddha Kapoor) in town